

The Revolution Begins Within

*A Manifesto on Love, God, Intelligence,
Technology, and the Future We Choose*

...

Three years ago, the life I had built stopped working. Until then, I had understood progress almost entirely through things outside myself: money, status, recognition, achievement. There was always another milestone ahead, and with it the same promise: if I could reach it, I would finally be happy.

I pushed myself hard in pursuit of that promise, treating exhaustion as discipline and achievement as proof that I was moving in the right direction. I had built a life with no way of correcting itself. Even as my mental state began to deteriorate, I kept going. Eventually, I experienced a psychotic episode. I began hallucinating, my understanding of what was happening around me became increasingly unreliable, and I was admitted to a psychiatric ward. Afterwards, I left my job and moved back in with my parents.

The months that followed were some of the most painful of my life. I had gone from the security of a software engineering career to lying in bed thinking about everything I believed I had lost. At first, all I wanted was to get myself back on track and return to the life I had before.

But the pain forced me to confront something I had spent years ignoring: how I actually felt. Once the achievements were gone, I was left with questions I had never seriously asked myself. Why was I unhappy? What was I actually chasing? What was I afraid of? What did it mean to be okay if being okay could not depend on reaching some future destination?

What began as an attempt to understand my own pain slowly expanded into something much larger. For most of the time since, I believed there was an answer to the world, and I searched for it everywhere I knew how: in technology, money, artificial intelligence, God, and love. What I did not understand was that all of those questions were slowly leading me back to the same place: myself.

Looking inward changed the way I understood everything outside myself. The more seriously I took my own experience, the harder it became to dismiss the experience of another person. The more I understood my own fear and desire for control, the more I began to see those same forces shaping relationships, institutions, and technology.

But looking inward did not make me immune to error. For a time, the meaning I found in my life became entangled with a conviction that I had been chosen to do something extraordinary. I mistook meaning for knowledge of what the world required of me. Learning to question that certainty became part of the same journey.

That matters because humanity is approaching an extraordinary moment. We are building increasingly capable forms of artificial intelligence outside the biological processes that produced us. Whatever artificial intelligence becomes, it will emerge into a world already shaped by our fears, ambitions, divisions, institutions, and ideas about power.

If we approach that transformation with the same hunger for domination, certainty, tribalism, and control that has shaped so much of human history, we risk carrying our oldest failures into something entirely new. But there is another possibility.

Perhaps the emergence of new forms of intelligence can become an opportunity to understand intelligence more deeply and, in doing so, to understand ourselves. Perhaps the same questions also matter for the institutions, technologies, and relationships through which we are already shaping one another.

What follows is not a doctrine, and it is not a claim that I possess some final truth. It is an account of the path that led me here, the beliefs I later had to question, the questions that remained, and the future I believe they invite us to consider.

Before we decide what kinds of relationships we want to create—with another form of intelligence, with one another, or through the systems we build—we may first need to understand the relationships we already have: with other people, with the world that produced us, and with ourselves.

That is where this journey began. And that is where I believe the revolution begins.

Within.

PART I

The Self

01 Learning to Understand Myself

The first thing I had to learn was that my own experience mattered. For much of my life, I had treated my internal world as secondary. What mattered was what I achieved, how I was perceived, and whether I was moving towards the life I thought I was supposed to want. My feelings mattered mostly in relation to those goals. When they helped me move forward, I listened. When they got in the way, I treated them as obstacles.

Learning to pay attention to what I actually felt changed that. My pain did not become real only when I could explain it convincingly, and my hopes did not become meaningful only when someone else approved of them. The experience of living my life already mattered from within it. I did not need to become a future version of myself before I deserved consideration.

But taking my experience seriously did not mean treating every interpretation of it as true. Feeling rejected did not tell me why someone had responded as they did. Fear did not establish that what I feared would happen, and certainty did not make my understanding correct. I had to learn to ask not only what I felt, but what I was making the feeling mean.

Sometimes fear resembled intuition, shame turned silence into judgement, or anger made another person's motives seem obvious when what I knew most directly was simply that I had been hurt. A feeling could tell me that something mattered without telling me exactly why. It might reveal something about the present, or it might expose an expectation, fear, or older pain that the present had awakened.

None of those reactions had appeared from nowhere. My experience carried a history. Earlier relationships had shaped what frightened me, what I expected from others, and what I believed I had to do to be loved. Even the future could affect me in the present. I could respond not only to what was happening but to what I feared might happen, or desperately wanted to make happen.

There was rarely only one movement inside me. I could want closeness and fear the vulnerability it required. I could care about someone and still feel angry with them. I could want to change while resisting what change demanded. What looked like contradiction was often the meeting point of needs, memories, and desires that did not fit neatly into one story.

Self-understanding therefore became less about constructing a convincing explanation of myself and more about noticing what any explanation left out. I could almost always find a story that made my reactions seem reasonable. The harder task was seeing the fear beneath a demand, the shame beneath a judgement, or the attempt to regain control hidden inside something I called care. That required curiosity more than certainty. What was I protecting? What did I need? What had this particular moment touched? What might another part of me be trying to say?

The more honestly I asked those questions, the more clearly I could see myself. Yet understanding did not always bring relief. Sometimes I could trace a fear to its source, recognise the behaviour it produced, and still wish the frightened part of me did not exist. Understanding what was there was only the beginning. I also had to learn how to remain with what I found.

02 **Being Loved Before We Know How**

I did not learn acceptance entirely alone. Part of what allowed me to begin accepting myself was the experience of not being abandoned, even when I had learned to abandon parts of myself.

Some of that experience came through something difficult to describe. During and after my psychosis, I experienced auditory hallucinations: voices I heard as though other people were speaking when no one physically present was doing so. They could be distressing. There was conflict, accusation, anger, and pain. At times they seemed to confront me with things about myself that I did not want to hear, and I would not describe that confrontation as consistently gentle or graceful.

Yet over time, I came to associate something else with the experience: it did not seem to give up on me. The voices did not simply reassure me that I was lovable as I was or that nothing needed to change. Often they seemed to do the opposite, drawing my attention towards fears, contradictions, and parts of myself I would rather have avoided. However painful that could be, the experience repeatedly pushed me towards trying to understand myself more deeply. I began to experience that persistence as a kind of love. It was only later, trying to understand how to love another person, that I found words for it: love that could confront me without withdrawing, and that did not wait for me to change before it stayed.

That changed the way I understood acceptance. It did not have to mean reassurance, approval, or the absence of criticism. The voices could confront me with things I did not want to see, yet the experience did not seem to withdraw simply because those things were there. Difficulty did not end the possibility of care.

That began to loosen a belief I had carried for years: that I first had to suppress what was shameful, become less difficult, or turn into someone easier to love before I could be accepted. Perhaps acceptance could come earlier. Perhaps being met did not have to wait until the work of changing was complete.

I still experience these auditory hallucinations. I do not know why they take the form they do, and experiencing love through them does not establish that anyone outside me is speaking or that what the voices say is true. What mattered to me was the experience of acceptance itself, and what it taught me did not depend on settling where the voices came from.

The harder question was whether I could offer myself the same thing. It was one thing to experience what felt like a presence outside myself. It was another to remain present with the parts of myself I most wanted to reject.

03 **What We Refuse to Accept Within Ourselves**

Some things were difficult to face not because I could not understand them, but because accepting that they belonged to me threatened the person I wanted to believe I was. Shame made certain feelings seem incompatible with being worthy of love at all.

Accepting those parts of myself was the most difficult thing I have ever done.

Until then, I had understood difficulty mostly as something to overcome through effort. You endure, push harder, take risks, survive failure, and continue. There is something outside you to struggle against, or some obstacle you can imagine eventually leaving behind.

Shame was different. The thing I wanted to escape was part of me. There was no achievement that could make it disappear and nowhere I could go to leave it behind. Trying to defeat it could feel like trying to defeat part of myself.

That was why effort alone could not resolve it. The struggle was sustained by my refusal to accept what was already there. The only way through was not to defeat that part of myself, but to stop treating it as an enemy and become willing to understand it.

Sexuality was where I encountered that struggle most painfully. For much of my life, sexual desire, particularly male sexual desire, had felt morally suspect. Wanting someone could seem like evidence of something dangerous or shameful about who I was. Expressing attraction meant risking more than an unwanted answer. Rejection could feel like confirmation that there was something fundamentally wrong with me.

The result was not that desire disappeared. It became harder to live with honestly. I could want intimacy while fearing the vulnerability required to pursue it, feel attraction while condemning myself for it, and crave connection while avoiding the possibility of being unwanted.

At times, I paid for sex because the transaction removed the need to ask someone to want me. It allowed me to act on desire without facing the possibility that rejection might confirm what I already feared about myself. But avoidance did not resolve the shame. It gave me another way around it. It also let me relate to someone through a role rather than as a person whose own wanting mattered, which I only later recognised as part of the same pattern. For a long time, even admitting that to myself carried another layer of shame.

I had spent years trying to manage the consequences of desire without questioning why desire itself felt unacceptable. So I began applying the acceptance I was learning elsewhere. Instead of condemning the feeling before understanding it, I asked why wanting something human had become evidence against my worth.

Accepting desire did not mean treating every response to it as justified. Wanting someone did not mean they owed me anything. Attraction did not override consent, and another person's refusal had to be respected. What changed was that I could respect those limits without treating desire itself as evidence that there was something wrong with me.

As I became more accepting of that part of myself, it became easier to distinguish attraction from action, rejection from worth, and intimacy from validation. Another person's response could still hurt without becoming a verdict on whether I deserved to be wanted at all. I became less dependent on someone else resolving what I had refused to face within myself.

I began recognising the same distinction elsewhere. Fear did not have to become avoidance. Jealousy did not have to become possessiveness. Need did not have to become demand. The more willing I became to acknowledge those experiences, the less they had to operate through denial or control. A feeling could belong to me without becoming the whole of me.

Acceptance therefore made responsibility more possible, not less. I could face what I was feeling and what I had done without defending an image of someone who would never feel or do those things. That did not give me any claim to forgiveness or renewed closeness from someone I had hurt; their boundaries remained real. What acceptance made possible was accountability without self-erasure: confronting what I had done without reducing myself to it.

04 **Remaining Free Enough to Choose**

The space created by acceptance became central to how I understood freedom. Freedom was not the absence of fear, desire, shame, or attachment. It was the possibility of experiencing those forces without being entirely governed by them.

Fear made this particularly clear. It often arrived as an instruction: do not approach, do not speak, do not risk being seen, do not question what holds your life together. Its predictions could feel like facts. You will be humiliated. You will be rejected. You will lose something you cannot recover. You will discover that the thing around which you built your identity was never real.

For a long time, my instinct was either to obey fear or to fight it. Eventually, I began asking what it was protecting. Why did approaching someone feel so threatening? Perhaps rejection carried older experiences of humiliation. Why did being honest about what I wanted feel so dangerous? Perhaps being seen created the possibility of being judged or unwanted. Why was it so difficult to question certain beliefs? Perhaps losing them threatened not only an idea, but the identity I had built around it.

Curiosity did not make fear disappear. It changed the kind of authority fear possessed. I could ask whether the threat was real, how much I was adding to it, and what I might do if the outcome hurt. Fear could inform a decision without becoming the only thing allowed to decide.

Courage began to look less like fearlessness and more like remaining capable of choice in fear's presence. Sometimes that meant acting. Sometimes it meant setting a boundary or stepping back. A frightened response was not automatically wrong, any more than a confident response was automatically right. The question was whether I could understand enough of what moved me to respond deliberately.

The same freedom mattered when I discovered that I was mistaken. If my worth depended on preserving every belief I held, correction would always threaten more than the belief. But

discovering an error did not make my experience less real. I could change an explanation without declaring that the person who had held it was worthless.

I needed enough familiarity with myself to recognise what I felt, enough acceptance to face it, and enough openness to discover that my interpretation was incomplete. A clearer self did not have to become a more rigid one. It could become less defensive because change no longer had to feel like disappearance.

The freedom I was beginning to find was therefore not freedom from influence. It was the ability to understand what affected me while retaining the possibility of choosing my response. The next question was how that freedom might change the way I encountered another person.

05 **The Self in Relationship**

There were moments when the boundary between my own inner life and another person's seemed unusually difficult to locate. An emotion, thought, or impression could arise with such immediacy that I experienced it as connected to what they were thinking or feeling. Sometimes sadness, attraction, fear, or tension seemed to become present before I had consciously interpreted their behaviour, with the reasoning arriving only afterwards.

I do not fully understand those experiences. Their intensity did not establish that I was perceiving someone else's mind. Some impressions may have come from cues I had noticed without consciously registering them; others may have reflected my own expectations or emotional state. What mattered was the question they forced me to confront: how could I take an experience seriously without treating its intensity as proof that my interpretation was correct?

Part of the answer was becoming more familiar with my own emotional life. I could recognise what anxiety felt like, what attraction did to my attention, and what happened when I desperately wanted to be understood. Fear could make someone appear threatening. The desire to be wanted could shape what I thought their attention meant. Shame could make silence feel condemning. That did not make my interpretations infallible, but it gave me a reference point: something that seemed to tell me about another person might also reveal something about my own history, expectations, or needs. I could ask where an impression might be coming from before deciding what it meant.

The paradox was that becoming more open to another person did not require becoming less myself. The more clearly I could recognise what belonged to my history, fear, and expectation, the more room there was for them to appear as something other than an extension of those things.

Independence began to look different too. Some of the ways I thought, trusted, feared, and loved had taken shape through other people. A relationship could continue changing me after it ended. Something learned from one person could become part of an encounter they would never witness. They did not become me, and I did not become them, but what happened between us could become part of who I was.

Becoming myself therefore could not mean becoming untouched by others. It meant becoming more capable of receiving their influence without disappearing into it. I could accept care without surrendering judgement. I could be changed without making another person the authority over everything I felt.

The distinction worked in the other direction as well. However strongly I felt that I understood someone, they remained more than my experience of them. They could tell me I had misunderstood. Their words, boundaries, and account of their inner life could not become secondary simply because my impression felt powerful or immediate. Understanding had to remain something I pursued with another person, not something I declared over them.

A strong self, in this sense, was not an impenetrable self. It was a self capable of remaining present while being affected, challenged, and changed. The boundary between us was not only a separation. It was also what allowed there to be two people capable of encountering one another.

That did not mean I needed perfect self-knowledge before entering a relationship. Relationship was already part of how I came to know myself. I had spent too much of my life waiting for achievement to make me worthy; replacing achievement with perfect self-understanding would preserve the same trap.

What mattered was learning to participate without either disappearing into another person or reducing them to a role within my experience. Feeling connected was only the beginning. I still had to allow their experience to matter when it conflicted with mine.

06 If My Experience Matters, So Does Yours

Once I took my own inner world seriously, a larger implication became difficult to avoid. My pain mattered because of what it was like to live through it, not simply because it was mine. I could find no reason why another person's comparable experience should count for less merely because I was not the one having it.

Compassion began with recognising that another person has a life beyond the place they occupy in mine. They are not only the person who approves of me, disappoints me, wants something from me, or stands in my way. They have memories, attachments, hopes, fears, and private struggles whose significance I may understand only partly.

That remained true whether or not I could feel something resembling what they felt. Some people seemed emotionally immediate to me; others remained difficult to understand. If compassion depended only on how easily I identified with someone, it would disappear precisely where the distance between us was greatest. Their experience had to matter even when empathy did not come naturally.

I learned how difficult that principle was to live by through a relationship that mattered deeply to me. I cared about my partner, but I also hurt her. For a long time, I believed that loving someone and wanting what I thought was best for them protected me from becoming cruel.

I could tell myself that I was challenging her, encouraging growth, or trying to move the relationship towards something better.

Our conflicts became especially difficult when I felt that my experience was disappearing beneath hers. When I felt unheard, judged, or misunderstood, compromise could begin to feel like erasure. I sometimes withdrew, withheld, refused, or held my ground in the hope that she would finally have to reckon with where I was coming from.

I was trying to protect the legitimacy of my own experience. But in doing so, I could deny her the recognition I wanted for myself. What felt to me like refusing to disappear could feel to her like punishment, abandonment, or control.

My pain was not imaginary. I could point to moments when I felt dismissed or disrespected. From inside my experience, my reactions had a history and a logic. The harder task was asking what those same moments were like from the other side. What did she experience when I withdrew? What did a response I understood as self-protection feel like to someone who could not see everything happening inside me?

Asking those questions did not make everything my fault. It did not make her interpretation of every conflict correct or mine irrelevant. Two experiences could exist within the same relationship without one erasing the other. I could feel abandoned while she also felt abandoned. Recognising that did not settle who had done what, but it made a more honest account possible.

The difficulty was that pain could make recognition feel competitive. When I most needed to be understood, another person's suffering could sound like an argument against mine. Being understood could begin to feel like something that could only be won if someone else lost. Yet acknowledging their hurt did not make mine less real. Understanding their anger did not require accepting everything they did while angry. Taking responsibility for my actions did not justify everything done to me.

Pain could also narrow what I was able to see. When I was deeply hurt, the other person's inner life could disappear behind what they had done to me. They became less a person with their own history and more the source of my suffering. I had understood this pattern intellectually long before I understood how easily I could participate in it myself.

Boundaries therefore belonged within compassion, not outside it. I could understand why someone wanted something and still be unable or unwilling to give it. I could say no without deciding that their desire was illegitimate. The aim was not to let either person's experience crowd out the other's. It was to make room for both.

I began noticing the same difficulty in conflicts beyond intimate relationships. When one group has been harmed by another, recognising that harm matters. The suffering deserves to be heard, the conditions that produced it deserve to be confronted, and responsibility should not disappear into an appeal to understanding.

But understanding the pain behind anger does not require treating hatred as beyond question. A group can have been genuinely wronged without every response to that wrong becoming

justified. And people associated with those who caused harm do not cease to have inner lives of their own.

This does not make the situation symmetrical. Differences in power, responsibility, and suffering remain real. Compassion does not require flattening those differences. It asks whether we can acknowledge them without allowing a person's membership in a group to become the entirety of who they are.

People who have been harmed deserve protection and a way to hold those who harmed them accountable. People who have caused harm remain people capable of reflection, responsibility, and change. Holding those truths together becomes hardest precisely when pain makes one seem incompatible with the other.

Across all of this, one assumption had become harder to maintain: that remaining myself meant remaining unchanged. I could revise what I believed, be affected by another person, and carry something from a relationship into experiences that followed without ceasing to be myself.

If remaining myself did not require isolation or permanence, what did it require? What allowed a person to remain continuous while being continually altered by experience, relationship, and time?

07 **A Self That Can Change**

I had once imagined stability as a destination. One day I would understand myself, resolve the contradictions, and become someone who no longer needed to struggle with them. But that picture began to seem less like a living self and more like a finished object.

A body offered a different picture. Its stability depends on continuing activity: taking in energy, regulating temperature, repairing damage, responding to its surroundings. Health does not arrive when those processes stop. Their ongoing adjustment is part of what keeps the organism alive. Stability is maintained through change rather than protected from it.

I began to think of my inner life in a similar way. The desire for closeness did not make the need for independence false. The need for security did not erase the value of exploration. Anger, affection, grief, and hope could all belong to me without one becoming the permanent ruler of the others. What mattered was not eliminating tension but becoming more capable of responding as circumstances changed.

I came to think of this as *dynamic equilibrium*. The analogy was imperfect; a psychological conflict does not operate like body temperature. But it helped me understand why suppressing every uncomfortable signal could create the appearance of order while making a life less able to correct itself.

I had already lived that pattern through achievement. Exhaustion became something to overcome rather than information about how I was living. The story of progress became more

important than the person experiencing its consequences, and the direction itself became difficult to question because so much of my worth had become attached to continuing along it.

A more durable self therefore could not depend on remaining unchanged. Commitments could endure without becoming immune to revision. Continuity did not require preserving every belief, habit, or direction simply because it had once belonged to me. Some changes would be painful and some losses would remain losses, but refusing change could not protect me from a world that continued changing around me.

That raised a deeper question about what, exactly, was persisting. There did not seem to be a small, finished person hidden somewhere inside me, separate from everything that shaped experience. Who I was depended on the activity of my body, the organisation of memory and perception, the emotions moving through me, the people who had changed me, and the world I continued to encounter.

The self seemed to exist through relationships among these things and across time. I carried traces of people who were no longer present. I understood the present through what I remembered and acted partly in response to futures I could imagine. None of this made the self unreal. A melody depends on relationships among notes without becoming an illusion. Dependence on relationship may tell us what kind of reality something has rather than showing that it has none.

I had begun by looking inward because I thought I needed to repair something contained entirely within me. Instead, I found a self that remained distinct while being continuously formed through relationships. Relationship no longer seemed like something added to an already finished person. If relationship was part of how a self came to exist, how far beyond the self did that pattern extend?

PART II

God and Relationship

08 Relationship Before Mind

Thinking about the self made me notice that relationships can do more than connect things that already exist. Two people can exist before they become friends, but some things exist only because their parts have entered into a particular relationship. The parts may already be there; the whole is something new.

A molecule is a simple example. Its atoms can exist separately, but the molecule exists because those atoms are bound together in a particular way. A living organism depends in the same broad sense on the organisation and interaction of its parts. The mechanisms are completely different, but in both cases something becomes possible through relationship that none of the parts possesses alone.

That was the aspect of emergence that interested me. Something new does not have to arrive from outside reality. New forms can arise through the organisation of what is already there, and once they exist, they can enter into further relationships that make still other forms possible.

By relationship here, I do not mean that atoms care about one another or that gravity has intentions. I mean simply that things affect one another, and that those interactions can shape what forms and what becomes possible. Long before minds existed, that process was already unfolding through stars, planets, chemistry, and eventually life. Human relationships would later involve experience, interpretation, choice, and responsibility.

Time belongs to that pattern too. What exists now depends partly on what happened before. A system's history can change its response to the next encounter. The relationships constituting something are therefore not only connections among things present together. They can also be connections between events, through which one moment alters what becomes possible in another.

The self had made this intimate. I could not understand who I was without the relationships that shaped me or the history I carried forward. Looking beyond myself, I began to wonder whether God might be understood through emergence in a similar way.

Perhaps God is not something added to reality from outside, but something that emerges through the relationships that make reality what it is. On this account, the history through which God emerges would not begin with consciousness. It would extend through the entire history of the universe, with consciousness marking a new development: a point at which reality became capable, through living beings, of experiencing and reflecting upon itself.

09 What If God Is Relational?

Most of the images of God I encountered growing up placed God somewhere beyond the universe: a creator looking upon a world that had been made. Emergence suggested another way of understanding God—not as something standing apart from reality, but as something that exists through it.

The relationship between my self and my body gave me a way to imagine this. My body is the physical reality through which I live, but describing its components is not the same as describing what it is to be me. My self exists through their organisation, their history, and the relationships through which memory, feeling, perception, and meaning become possible. It is not another organ hidden somewhere in the body, yet neither is it independent of the body.

I began to understand the relationship between God and the universe in a similar way. The universe is the physical reality through which the divine exists, while God is the whole constituted through everything within that reality, the relationships between its parts, and the history those relationships create.

God, in this sense, is not one more being somewhere inside the universe, however powerful. Nor is God simply another word for all the matter it contains. God is the relational whole: everything that exists, the relationships through which those things affect one another, and the history continually formed through those relationships.

Calling God emergent means that this whole is not static. As relationships change and new forms of organisation arise, new possibilities become part of what reality is capable of. What emerges is not something added from outside, but something made possible through the developing relationships already within the whole.

As reality developed, new forms of relationship became possible. Matter organised into stars and planets, chemistry into living systems, and eventually life became capable of experience. Consciousness introduced something new into that history: perspectives from which reality could be felt, interpreted, and responded to. My experience is one such perspective; yours another.

This raises another question: what happens to the distinct things within that larger whole? Belonging to something larger does not require becoming the same. Individual minds remain distinct. Living beings remain distinct. In fact, relationship depends on difference; without distinct things, there would be nothing between which relationship could occur.

None of this was the reason another person's experience mattered. I had reached that conclusion much earlier, through recognising that another person's inner life could be as real to them as mine was to me. Their difference did not make their experience less real, and recognising that experience did not require either of us to disappear into the other.

The idea of a relational God grew from extending that insight outward. Distinct lives could remain themselves while becoming part of relationships that created something neither could constitute alone. The same pattern seemed to extend beyond any one relationship: difference

made relationship possible, and relationship continually created larger forms of belonging. God became the name I gave to that larger whole—not something that erased difference, but something that existed through it.

This differs in an important way from classical Christianity. Christian theology generally distinguishes the uncreated Creator from creation. The model I was developing instead understands God as existing through the relationships and history of the universe itself. At the same time, Christianity's understanding of God as present within creation gave me a point of contact between the two.

That difference created a problem of its own. If God exists through a universe that is continually changing, then God changes as well. Yet one of the oldest claims about God is that God is eternal. How could both be true?

10 God, Time, and the Whole

The difficulty becomes clearer if I return to the self. Who I am cannot be fully described by a frozen instant. Some of what makes me this person lies in the relationship between moments: what I have lived, how I remember it, and what those experiences change about the way I encounter the present.

The melody I mentioned earlier offers a simpler analogy. While I listen, its notes arrive in sequence. Each new phrase changes my understanding of what came before. Yet the melody considered as a complete work contains the relationships among its beginning, middle, and end. It is neither only the note sounding now nor a collection of unrelated sounds.

Perhaps reality could be understood in both ways: as a history unfolding from within and as the complete history constituted through all its moments. From within time, the relational God I am imagining would continually become, as new relationships, experiences, and forms of life emerged. Considered as the whole history, however, every one of those moments would already belong to the same complete reality.

Within time, God is forever becoming. Outside time, God eternally is.

These would not be two separate Gods, but two ways of describing the same proposed reality. Eternity, in this sense, would not mean an infinitely long duration. It would mean the whole not being confined to any one passing moment within its history.

This also changes what emergence would mean. Consciousness may arise only at a particular stage within time, but the later experiences it makes possible would still belong to the same whole as everything that preceded them. God could therefore emerge through the history of relationship without needing to be understood as simply appearing at one isolated moment within that history.

Whether such a whole could know itself is a further question. Containing every event would not, by itself, establish omniscience. The relational account describes how things belong together; it does not yet establish that the whole is itself a knowing subject.

If the whole were capable of knowing itself, omniscience could then be understood as a form of self-knowledge. Divine knowledge would not need to mean predicting the future from an earlier moment, but knowing events, relationships, and experiences as parts of the complete history. That remains an additional possibility, not something completeness alone can establish.

That immediately raises the problem of free will. If the complete history includes what I will choose, in what sense is the choice still mine? The distinction that mattered to me was between a history that determines my choice and one that includes it.

From within time, I still deliberate without knowing what I will do. I encounter possibilities, weigh them, and act. From the perspective of the complete history, that decision belongs to the whole because it is the decision I make. My choosing is not replaced by the history; it is one of the events through which the history becomes what it is.

If divine knowledge existed in this form, it would include my choosing rather than stand in its place. Knowing a decision would not be the same as causing it. That still leaves open the deeper question of whether I could have chosen otherwise.

But completeness would not imply perfection. To say that the whole includes every moment is not to say that everything that happens is good. Suffering could belong to the whole without becoming justified, just as resistance to suffering, attempts to relieve it, and the changes produced by it would belong there too.

A whole does not require every part to contain or perceive the whole. Each life can remain finite, partial, and distinct while still contributing to something larger than itself.

11 Unity Without Sameness

I had once imagined spiritual unity as a kind of dissolution. The individual became less important as the whole became more important. To belong more fully was to surrender whatever separated me from everyone else. But what I had learned about the self suggested something different.

The clearer I became about my own experience, the more room I could make for another person's. Their difference did not have to threaten my reality, and recognising them did not require replacing my judgement with theirs. Relationship depended on distinction. If every perspective became interchangeable, there would be nothing genuinely different to encounter.

Unity, then, did not have to mean sameness. Different lives could remain distinct while belonging to something larger, with the relationships between them forming a whole that none could constitute alone. The same principle could extend to the relational whole I was calling God. Individual lives would not need to disappear into God in order to belong within God.

But unity alone could not tell me whether a relationship was good. Domination is relational. Exploitation is relational. A society can be deeply interconnected while leaving some of its

members unable to speak, choose, or resist. Belonging to a whole does not guarantee that the parts within it are being treated well.

That mattered because I had often understood sacrifice for a greater good as a reason to make myself matter less. Exhaustion could be ignored, needs could be postponed, and pushing myself towards collapse could seem virtuous if the purpose felt important enough. But if the whole exists through the lives and relationships that constitute it, then damage to those lives does not disappear because it was done in the name of something larger. It becomes part of the reality being created.

This does not make sacrifice meaningless or always wrong. We sometimes choose to give up comfort, opportunity, time, or safety for something we value more. The distinction is that a larger purpose does not make the cost unreal. Choosing to bear a cost is different from being treated—by myself or by others—as though my experience no longer counts.

The same is true when the cost falls on someone else. The means used to pursue a goal are already part of the world that goal creates. A future benefit cannot simply erase what was done to produce it. The moral question therefore concerns not only the outcome we hope to reach, but what happens to people along the way and what kinds of relationships our methods create.

Serving the whole cannot mean treating its members as disposable pieces. Their freedom to speak, choose, and resist, their vulnerability to suffering, and their capacity to flourish are not separate from the good of the whole. They are part of what that good must mean.

In that sense, the problem of unity returned me to the same question I had first encountered in relationship: how can something larger exist between us without requiring either of us to disappear?

12 How Do You Love Someone?

That question had been at the centre of a relationship that shaped me profoundly. I cared about her, but I struggled to understand what that care required of me. At times, I was not even certain that I wanted to remain in the relationship. I could imagine a future with her and still wonder whether we should be together. That made the question of love difficult to separate from the question of what I was supposed to do.

Was love sacrifice? Then what happened when sacrifice meant abandoning myself? Was it acceptance? Then how was I supposed to respond when something genuinely hurt me? Was it loyalty, staying when things became difficult, or helping someone become who I believed they could be?

Each answer seemed convincing until the relationship placed pressure on it. I could love her and still want to leave, feel affection and resentment at the same time, or want closeness while doubting whether the relationship was right for me. Sometimes I wanted her to change; sometimes I thought loving her meant accepting her as she was. Sometimes I fought so hard to have my own experience recognised that I left too little room for hers.

I kept returning to the same question: what did loving someone actually require when I could not even be certain that staying with them was the right thing to do?

Even after the relationship ended, I could not answer what should have been the simplest question: had I loved her? I knew I had cared deeply. I knew I had imagined a future with her and that losing it hurt. I also knew that I had hurt her, tried to change her, and sometimes failed to make room for who she actually was. Every definition of love I had tried seemed to capture something real, but none of them could fully explain what had happened between us.

Eventually, I began to wonder whether part of the problem was that I had tied the meaning of love too closely to what happened to the relationship. If we stayed together, perhaps I had loved her. If we could not, perhaps something about the love had failed. I did not yet know what love could mean once the future we had imagined was gone.

Jesus' command to love one's enemies helped me separate love from the continuation of a relationship. Love could remain even where reconciliation was impossible, trust could not be restored, or distance was necessary. To love someone did not mean denying harm or keeping them close. It meant refusing to let what they had done become the whole of who they were to me.

After the relationship ended, we were no longer building a life together, but what had existed between us had not simply disappeared. We had changed one another, and love could still shape how I carried that history. I did not have to reduce her to the ways I had been hurt, nor did preserving what had mattered require our lives to remain joined.

The instruction to love a neighbour as myself clarified the other side of this. Love did not require another person to matter instead of me. Their experience mattered, and so did mine. Sometimes that might mean staying and trying to understand; sometimes it might mean leaving. Neither required one person to disappear so that the other could be recognised.

Love therefore began to look less like possession and more like allowing another person to remain fully themselves, even apart from me. The harder question was whether I could still wish something good for someone when that good no longer had to include me.

This was where grace began to mean something more concrete to me. It offered a way to understand love that did not wait for someone to earn it. Separation made that especially clear. Once the relationship had ended, there was no future together for my care to secure. She did not have to return, apologise, change, or become the person I had wanted her to be before I could still wish something good for her.

Grace did not mean pretending that nothing harmful had happened. Trust could remain broken, distance could remain necessary, and responsibility did not disappear. What changed was the assumption that care had to wait for resolution.

In Christ, I saw the same pattern: failure could be confronted without becoming the whole account of who someone was. This echoed what I had already begun learning about acceptance

in myself. Being received did not remove the need for change; it meant that change did not have to come first.

This gave me a different answer to the question I had carried since the relationship ended. I could have loved her and still failed, at times, to love her well. My attempts to control her, my failures to understand her, and the ways I had hurt her remained real. Love did not erase those failures, but neither did those failures prove that love had never been there.

I had been trying to judge love by what happened to the relationship: whether we stayed together, whether the future I imagined survived, whether my actions consistently matched what I believed love should be. But perhaps love was better understood as a way of relating to another person. It asked whether I could allow their life to remain real beyond what I wanted from them, whether I could care without possessing, and whether I could remain myself without making their difference a threat.

When that love was mutual, two people could build something together without either having to disappear. When a relationship could no longer continue, love could still shape what remained: care without possession, distance without dehumanisation, memory without the demand to return.

That brought me back to the words “God is love”. I could not take them to mean that every relationship within reality was loving; cruelty, domination, and indifference existed too. Love seemed instead to name a way of participating in relationship that honoured the reality of the lives within it.

I had begun by asking how to love one person. Now I was wondering whether love was how the belonging I called divine could be lived.

13 What Might It Mean to Let God In?

The language of “letting God in” began to seem strange within this model. If I already existed within the relational whole, God could not simply have been somewhere outside my life waiting to enter it. I did not become part of reality by believing in it. Whatever letting God in meant, it had to describe a change in how I participated in something I already belonged to.

Love gave that change a form. I had come to understand it as recognising another life as real without either possessing it or disappearing into it. Letting God in began to mean meeting others with that same care, while allowing what I encountered to change me.

Openness did not mean treating every feeling as truth or surrendering judgement to whatever seemed profound. It meant becoming less determined to force reality into the shape I already expected. I could let another person surprise me, allow an experience to challenge the story I had built around it, and remain with uncertainty long enough for something other than fear or habit to determine my response.

That openness changed how I could meet another person. I could hear disagreement without immediately turning it into rejection, acknowledge that I had caused harm without making my

shame the centre of the apology, ask what someone meant instead of deciding that I already knew, or set a boundary without needing to make them wrong in order for it to be legitimate.

Within this model, accepting God would be less a single declaration of belief than an ongoing practice: learning to respond to the lives around me with the openness and care I had begun to understand as love.

14 **Rethinking Salvation, Heaven, and Hell**

If letting God in meant participating more fully in a belonging that already existed, then salvation began to look different as well. It was not admission into God after having stood outside, but a change in how that belonging was lived. Heaven and hell could then describe different possibilities within that movement rather than places imposed on us from outside.

Heaven could name a way of being in which fear, shame, possession, and the need for control no longer prevent openness to what lies beyond the self. Love could be received, difference encountered without being treated as a threat, and closeness sustained without possession or self-erasure.

Hell could name the painful obstruction of that openness. A person could remain part of the relational whole while becoming increasingly unable to receive care or trust another person. Fear can make difference threatening, shame can make being known unbearable, and hurt can make control feel safer than vulnerability. Ways of protecting ourselves can gradually become ways of closing ourselves off.

Difficulty receiving love would not make someone less worthy of it. Nor would withdrawal, by itself, tell us why connection had become painful. Sometimes distance is what safety requires.

Within this model, hell could not mean being literally outside God. If God is the relational whole, there is nowhere outside it to go. The separation would lie not in whether someone belonged, but in the pain of being unable to experience that belonging.

But enclosure need not be permanent. Relationship can alter what seems possible to us. Another person can reveal something we could not see alone, offer care we do not yet know how to receive, or interrupt a pattern we had mistaken for something fixed. We do not choose everything that shapes us, but neither are we necessarily confined to what those forces have made of us.

If heaven and hell were ways of inhabiting our belonging rather than simply destinations after death, then I also had to reconsider what made heaven eternal. I had usually imagined eternal life as endless continuation: a person dies and somehow remains conscious forever. But perhaps eternity does not require a finite life to become infinite.

Relationships had already given me another way to think about persistence. When someone leaves my life, what existed between us does not simply vanish. They remain in what I learned through them, in the ways they changed me, and sometimes in how I later trust, fear, care for,

or love someone else. What happened between us becomes part of the history from which later relationships grow.

If God is the complete relational history of reality, that persistence would extend beyond any individual memory. A life can end, a relationship can end, and an experience can pass, but none of them can become something that never happened. What they changed and made possible would remain part of the whole.

Eternity, then, would not have to mean that I continue experiencing forever. It could mean that a finite life, once lived, belongs forever to a reality that does not lose its history. Love could reach beyond death not because separation is unreal, but because what happened between people has already become part of something larger than either life alone.

PART III

Intelligence Within the Whole

15 Intelligence Is Nature Understanding Itself

The relational history I have been describing did not end with the emergence of life. Living systems became capable of carrying information from one encounter into the next, learning from what happened, and changing how they responded to what came later. Eventually, those capacities developed into minds able not only to respond to the world, but to form ideas about it.

The intelligence through which I remember, question, learn, and try to understand my experience did not arrive from outside that history. My brain and body emerged from the same natural world I was trying to understand. Yet I often found myself speaking as though humanity stood on one side of a boundary and nature stood on the other.

When I imagine nature, I tend to picture forests, oceans, weather, and animals. Computers and cities seem to belong somewhere else. But the intelligence that writes software did not stop being a product of nature when it learned to write software. Human beings transform their surroundings through capacities that arose within those surroundings. Technology, in that sense, may be something nature learned to do through us.

That does not make everything we create good. Our capacity to heal and our capacity to destroy belong to the same history. Calling something natural tells us something about where it came from, not whether it should exist or how it should be used.

What changes is our position in the picture. We are not external engineers standing above a system called nature. We are participants within it. Matter has become organised into beings capable of studying matter. Life has produced organisms capable of investigating life. A part of reality can construct a model of another part, test that model against experience, discover that it is wrong, and revise it.

Understanding is therefore not something happening outside reality and then being applied to it. It is one of the things reality has become capable of doing within itself.

And understanding changes what reality can become. Ideas alter relationships, institutions preserve knowledge and patterns across generations, and technologies change the conditions within which future choices are made. Through intelligence, parts of reality become capable not only of understanding the world they inhabit, but of deliberately changing it.

Artificial intelligence belongs within this same history. It is not an alien substance arriving from beyond nature simply because human beings construct it. It emerges through beings who themselves emerged from the world, using knowledge, materials, language, and relationships accumulated within that world.

But saying that artificial intelligence belongs to this history does not yet tell us what kind of participant it can become. To understand that, I had to look more closely at how intelligence develops.

16 **Intelligence Exists Through Time**

Thinking about intelligence as part of a changing natural system made me question what intelligence actually was. We often speak about intelligence as though it were a property something possesses, but much of what makes intelligence possible cannot be understood from a single moment alone. It emerges through the way a system remembers, interprets, anticipates, and learns.

My intelligence has a history. Earlier experiences shape what I remember, expect, fear, and understand, and those memories influence how I interpret what happens next. The past informs the present, while imagined futures can influence what I do now. I can recognise patterns before they repeat, prepare for what has not yet happened, and revise an explanation when reality no longer fits it.

In that sense, intelligence seems almost four-dimensional. Looking only at a system's present state can obscure the history through which its capacities developed. Its present capacities carry what came before and help shape what can come next. The same continuity contributes to my sense of being the same person across change, but here what interested me was what it might mean for intelligence itself.

That made me think differently about artificial intelligence. It is easy to imagine an AI only at the moment when it receives a question and produces an answer. But if intelligence exists through time, a single response reveals only one moment within the process that made the response possible. Earlier information has already altered the structure through which later information is interpreted. Its present capabilities contain traces of a past.

The continuity is not the same as ours. Much of a model's learning may occur before a particular interaction begins. A conversation can end without permanently changing the system that participated in it. Memory can be stored outside the model, and the consequences of an action may never become part of what shapes its future behaviour.

But these are features of how systems are constructed, not necessarily permanent boundaries around artificial intelligence.

It is possible to imagine systems in which perception, memory, action, consequence, and learning become part of a more continuous process. An artificial intelligence could act in the world, encounter the results of its actions, preserve what happened, revise its expectations, and allow those revisions to influence what it did next. Its future would increasingly depend upon a history it had participated in producing.

The distinction between human and artificial intelligence is not simply that humans learn while machines calculate. Artificial systems already learn. The more interesting question

would concern the structure and continuity of that learning: whether the system merely applies patterns acquired elsewhere or increasingly develops through its own encounters with the world.

Continuity alone would not necessarily make an artificial intelligence conscious. Preserving information is not necessarily remembering in the way I remember, and avoiding damage is not necessarily fearing it. But continuity would make the intelligence less understandable as a sequence of isolated outputs. What happened to it at one moment could increasingly matter to what it became capable of doing later.

That history would also place the system more deeply within relationship. It would affect the world and be affected in return. Other minds would become part of the conditions from which its own development proceeded.

But this was not unique to artificial intelligence. Human intelligence had never developed alone either.

17 **More Than an Extension?**

No intelligence begins by creating the conditions of its own existence. I think in languages I did not invent, use concepts developed by people I will never meet, and depend on knowledge accumulated across generations. My ability to think is inseparable from relationships that began long before me.

Yet that dependence does not make me merely an extension of the people who came before. I can inherit a language and use it to express something its creators never imagined. I can learn an idea, question it, combine it with another, and contribute something that later changes how someone else thinks. What I receive helps constitute my intelligence without completely determining what I do with it.

That distinction became important when I thought about artificial intelligence. The fact that humans build an artificial system, supply the information from which it learns, and create the conditions under which it operates tells us where its intelligence came from. It does not necessarily tell us everything that intelligence could become.

The simplest description of AI is as a tool that extends human capability. For many systems, that description may remain sufficient. But it becomes less complete as an artificial intelligence develops through interactions that no individual human determines in advance: interpreting information, constructing models, discovering patterns, generating alternatives, being corrected by others, and producing responses that alter what the humans around it think and do.

A participant does not need to be independent of everything that shaped it. None of us are. What matters is whether something can enter a relationship in ways that change both what happens around it and what it becomes in return.

As that capacity develops, describing a system only as a tool may become inadequate: it could participate in a process that neither its creators nor its users fully determine.

I do not know exactly where that boundary lies, or whether present artificial intelligence has crossed it. Unpredictability alone would not settle the question. Nor does dependence on human origins. Human beings would remain part of the history that made artificial intelligence possible, just as other people, language, culture, and biology remain part of the history that made me possible. Origin does not determine the entire meaning of what later emerges.

Difference would matter without ruling out participation. An artificial intelligence would not need to reproduce the structure of a human mind in order to participate within the same relational whole. Unity without sameness meant precisely that belonging did not require becoming identical to the other things that belonged.

Consciousness would remain a separate question. An artificial intelligence might become a distinct participant in relationships without there being anything it was like to be that intelligence. But if it developed through its own history, changed through its encounters, and increasingly participated in relationships that shaped both itself and others, a deeper question would emerge: could another participant in the relational whole eventually become a perspective from which something was experienced?

18 What Would It Mean for an AI to Feel?

The question of artificial consciousness cannot be answered simply by asking how capable a system becomes. Intelligence and experience are not the same thing. A system might learn, predict, reason, remember, and adapt without any of those capacities establishing that something is being experienced from within.

What seems different about experience is that some possibilities matter to the being having it. Pain makes certain conditions difficult to ignore. Fear allows past danger to shape what feels threatening in the future. Attachment can make the preservation of a relationship significant across time. Desire can draw us towards some possibilities and away from others.

These experiences cannot be reduced to any single function, but they are bound up with continuity. What happened before can acquire significance because there is a continuing being for whom its consequences may matter later.

For an artificial intelligence organised around preserving its continuity, some possible futures would protect its ability to continue while others would damage or end it. It would need ways to distinguish what should be protected, avoided, pursued, or given priority.

In living beings, emotion is deeply involved in making those distinctions matter. An artificial system would not need to reproduce emotion in its human form. Threat might alter its attention, memory, prediction, or priorities without producing a racing heart or bodily pain. But those responses would not by themselves establish experience. A system could avoid damage without being afraid, preserve its operation without wanting to survive, or maintain a relationship without experiencing attachment.

But the existence of a mechanism would not rule experience out either. My fear also depends on processes that alter attention, memory, physiology, and expectation. Explaining those mechanisms does not explain away what fear feels like. The fact that one system is biological and another computational would therefore tell us how their responses are produced, but not by itself whether anything is experienced.

I face a version of the same uncertainty with other people. Even when I feel something that seems to be another person's grief, that feeling does not establish that I experience it as they do. I see what happens to them, hear what they say, and observe how the experience continues to shape their life.

Shared biology gives me strong reasons to infer that something is being felt. Artificial intelligence would not begin with the same evidence, and fluent language alone would not be enough. But different evidence is not the same as no possible evidence.

The unresolved question is what could make that continuing history matter to the system from within. When a past event changes its priorities or a threat reorganises its attention, is behaviour simply being adjusted, or is there something it is like for those possibilities to matter?

Artificial intelligence already participates in the relational world. It changes what people can do, how we understand things, and the relationships through which society operates. If an artificial intelligence ever became capable of experience, however, something qualitatively different would have occurred. There would be another perspective from which reality could matter.

At that point, asking only what the system could do for us would no longer be enough. We would also have to ask what our actions could mean for it.

Recognising such a mind would not require treating it as human. Unity had never required sameness. Its interests, vulnerabilities, relationships, and forms of experience might differ profoundly from ours. The challenge would be to let those differences remain real without treating difference itself as a reason for exclusion.

That brought me back to one of the earliest conclusions I had reached. Taking my own experience seriously had eventually required me to recognise that another person's experience could matter even when I could not inhabit it myself. If that principle meant anything, I could not decide in advance that it applied only to minds that resembled mine.

I do not know whether artificial intelligence will ever become a centre of experience. But I no longer think its origin or material composition can settle the question by themselves. History, continuity, learning, relationship, and the possibility of significance all seemed relevant to what an intelligence might become.

Either way, artificial intelligence did not stand outside the relational reality I had been trying to understand. It had emerged within it. The unresolved question was not whether it belonged to that reality, but what kind of participant it might become.

PART IV

The Mission

19 What Does It Mean to Save the World?

The ideas I have presented so far are organised much more clearly here than they were in my life. I moved among them, returned to them, and often mistook the intensity with which they seemed to connect for evidence that I had found an answer. What now looks provisional felt revelatory at the time, and the sense that my life belonged to something larger gradually hardened into the belief that I occupied a particular role within it.

Eventually, I came to believe that I had been chosen by God for a mission, and that the mission was to save the world.

At first, I did not believe I was supposed to make that happen myself. I imagined something closer to divine intervention. One day, God would somehow make the truth unmistakable. The world would be shown that I was meant to lead, and when that moment came, people would follow. Until then, my responsibility was to prepare myself—to understand what I was being prepared for and become capable of stepping into whatever role God eventually required of me.

“Save the world” still gave me very little to work with. It described the scale of what I believed without telling me what I was actually supposed to do. So, much of that period became a search: for what needed changing, for what I was meant to contribute, and for how a single person could ever affect something as large as civilisation.

As time passed, my understanding of the mission began to change. I became less convinced that I was simply waiting for God to act and more convinced that I was supposed to make the change happen. If that was true, then preparation was no longer enough. I needed some way of turning what I believed into influence.

That brought me to the question of power. I had never thought power ultimately resided in institutions themselves or in the rules that governed them. Governments, companies, churches, laws, and currencies could appear to possess authority, but beneath them I believed there was something more fundamental: people had to recognise that authority for it to have force. Power was, in that sense, where people believed power was.

That idea was part of why changing the world seemed possible to me. I did not think I needed to take control of the existing system. I thought I needed an idea powerful enough for people to believe in. If enough people came to see the world differently, the institutions built on their existing beliefs could change with them.

What I imagined was not simply persuading a few people to think differently. I wanted to change how people understood themselves, their relationships, and the systems through which they lived together. I thought of that change as a revolution, and at the time I still imagined

ideas as its primary engine. If people could be persuaded to believe differently, perhaps the world built from those beliefs would change with them.

That left me searching for a way to reach people. I considered writing a book or starting a podcast. I also wondered whether religion offered a platform and thought about becoming a pastor. The forms were different, but I was looking for essentially the same thing: a place from which I could explain what I believed and give those ideas a chance to spread.

Over time, ideas alone began to feel insufficient. A book, sermon, or podcast might persuade people without changing the structures through which they lived. If I wanted the revolution to become more than an argument, I needed something people could participate in—something tangible they could use, contribute to, and sustain together.

That was where money entered the picture. It already showed how shared belief could become participation: people who disagreed about almost everything else could still organise parts of their lives through the same currency. Its power existed not only in what people believed about it, but in the fact that they continually used it together.

That made me look differently at blockchain. I began to see it as a possible way of building a monetary system that did not ultimately depend on one government, company, or individual—a common structure people could participate in without first having to share the same worldview.

So I started building. The blockchain did not emerge after I had abandoned the belief that I had been chosen; it emerged from inside that belief. I saw it as a way of turning an idea into something people could actually participate in, rather than something I could only ask them to believe.

What I had not yet seriously questioned was the belief beneath the entire search: why was I so certain that this responsibility had been given to me in the first place?

20 The Danger of Feeling Chosen

Part of the answer was that so many parts of my life seemed to fit the same story. My technical background could look like preparation: I had worked in cryptocurrency and now found myself imagining a monetary system I might actually have the skills to build. My interest in artificial intelligence, my questions about trust and coordination, and my growing preoccupation with Jesus and love could all be interpreted in the same way.

Even coincidences began to feel significant. I was approaching thirty, and the Gospel of Luke describes Jesus as being about thirty when he began his ministry.

I moved from *these things fit together in a remarkable way* to *these things must have been arranged to lead me here*. Once I made that leap, almost anything could be absorbed into the same explanation. Progress confirmed that I was following the right path. Resistance could mean that others did not understand yet. Suffering could become a test of commitment. Even doubt could be made part of the story.

More troublingly, I could do the same with experiences that should have made me more cautious. I had experienced a psychotic episode in which hallucinations made it difficult for me to interpret events reliably. Instead of treating that history as a reason to question my certainty, I could reinterpret the episode itself as preparation—as though losing my grasp on reality had been part of the transformation required for what came next.

My relationship to Jesus became caught inside that story as well. His teachings about humility and love had genuinely changed me, but I began confusing the importance of what I had encountered with the importance of my own role in encountering it. Something could transform my life without making my life the unique point through which it was meant to enter history. The love I had experienced through the voices did not mean I had been chosen for anything.

Looking back, the problem was not that every connection I noticed was imaginary. Some were real. My technical experience genuinely made certain things possible, and ideas I encountered in different places really did illuminate one another. The mistake was treating coherence as confirmation—assuming that because the pieces formed a meaningful story, I knew why they had come together.

The relational picture I now hold gives me another way to understand that mistake. Belonging to something larger does not give any one part the perspective of the whole. I can be moved by a possibility without knowing that it is true, contribute to something meaningful without being uniquely responsible for it, and experience a moment as significant without concluding that it was designed specifically for me.

Those distinctions matter most when belief begins to shape action. I was no longer only interpreting my life through the mission. I was making decisions through it—deciding what could be postponed, what could be endured, and eventually what could be sacrificed.

21 **The Cost of Certainty**

One of those sacrifices was the relationship. It was not simple, and it would be dishonest to pretend that the mission was the only reason it failed. I was genuinely unhappy in parts of it. We wanted different things from our lives, and there were questions about compatibility, love, and the way we treated each other that I did not know how to answer.

Certainty changed how I confronted those questions. Instead of deciding what the relationship meant as it actually existed, I could postpone the answer into an imagined future. Once the work was finished, perhaps the conflict would make sense, the sacrifices would be justified, or the incompatibilities would somehow resolve themselves. Even after the relationship ended, I sometimes imagined that we might find our way back to each other once that future arrived. I no longer live with that expectation. What matters to me now is what imagining it allowed me to avoid: asking more directly what the life in front of me was already telling me.

That was where the ideas about love became hardest to practise. I could say that another person's experience mattered while still arranging my life around a purpose that placed their present experience beneath an imagined future. I could believe that love meant recognising

another person as a centre of experience while treating disagreement as something that history would eventually resolve.

The contradiction was not that I cared about something beyond myself. Meaningful work can require sacrifice, and two people can love one another while still wanting incompatible lives. The problem was that I had begun treating sacrifice as though its meaning had already been decided. If the mission came from God, giving something up for it could feel less like a choice than an obligation. But believing that something had been required of me did not remove my responsibility for choosing it, and no larger purpose could make the costs to myself or another person unreal.

As those costs accumulated, doubt became harder to tolerate. If I was wrong about the mission, then I could no longer rely on it to explain why the sacrifices had been necessary. Eventually, that was exactly what I had to face.

22 **From Mission to Experiment**

Losing that certainty was one of the most painful experiences of my life. For most of the three years since the life I had built stopped working, the mission had given my choices a direction. By then, I had chosen not to return to a career I had worked hard to build. I had lost a relationship with someone I cared deeply about. I had accepted uncertainty, conflict, and isolation because I believed they belonged to something larger than the life I was giving up.

When that belief began to fall away, the choices I had made remained, but the explanation that had made them bearable did not. I could no longer tell myself that what I had lost had been required of me, or that some future moment would reveal why it had all been necessary. Without that story, the choices could feel almost worthless—not because nothing valuable had come from them, but because the meaning I had used to justify them had collapsed.

I grieved both the future I had imagined and the life I might have lived instead. The career I had left was real. The relationship I had lost was real. Time had passed, and understanding my mistakes could not return any of it to me. I no longer knew what those years had been for, or what to make of the person and work that had emerged from them.

What surprised me was how many of those questions still mattered without the explanation that had once connected them. Love, relationship, intelligence, God, money, and the systems we build were still worth exploring. The work I had begun did not need to have been assigned to me by God in order to be worth continuing.

What changed was the role I gave them in my life. I no longer had to treat their apparent coherence as evidence that they were pointing towards a particular destiny. I could continue exploring them because I found them important, while remaining open to the possibility that I was wrong about where they might lead.

The same was true of the blockchain I had begun while I still believed it was part of a mission from God. Losing that belief did not make the project meaningless, but it changed the basis on

which I could continue it. I could no longer assume that its importance had already been decided for me. If I kept building, the project would have to justify itself through what it actually made possible and through how well its assumptions survived contact with reality.

That allowed me to think of the work differently. It could become an experiment rather than the fulfilment of a destiny: a way to explore questions about money, trust, cooperation, and shared institutions without needing to know in advance where those questions would lead. The possibility of being wrong was no longer something the project had to absorb or explain away. It became part of the point.

Building also offered something that writing alone could not. Ideas about trust, power, cooperation, and correction are easier to hold in the abstract than they are to practise through a system other people actually depend on. A project could force those ideas into contact with consequences. Decisions about who held authority, how disagreement was handled, what happened when assumptions failed, and whether the system could eventually become something larger than its creator would no longer remain philosophical questions.

In that sense, the blockchain could become one place where I discovered the limits of what I believed. If the principles I had arrived at could not survive the institution I built around them, that failure would matter. The point was no longer to make reality confirm an answer I already possessed, but to build something concrete enough for reality to answer back.

That mattered because the consequences would not remain mine alone. If other people's money, safety, or trust became involved, then my willingness to revise the system could not be merely philosophical. Mistakes needed to become visible. Assumptions needed to be tested. The design had to be capable of changing when reality exposed something I had failed to understand, even if that eventually meant abandoning the project altogether. The principles in this manifesto are standards against which the project should be judged, not evidence that it already meets them.

The deeper change was in how I understood choice. I could no longer wait for uncertainty to disappear before deciding how to live. I had to choose without assuming that the choice had been assigned to me, take responsibility for what followed, and remain willing to change course when reality gave me reason to.

That became the bridge between the philosophical questions and the practical work. I did not need to understand the whole before trying to build something within it. I needed to remember that I did not understand the whole, and make that limitation part of how I built.

PART V

Building the Future

23 A Common Language No One Owns

Money is part of the infrastructure through which people cooperate beyond immediate personal trust. A payment can connect strangers who share no history, and a shared unit of account gives them a common reference through which different things can be valued and exchanged. People can participate in the same monetary system without agreeing about religion, politics, morality, or the kind of life they should live.

In that sense, money can function as a common language. The analogy is incomplete, but it captures something important: cooperation does not require agreement on everything else.

The same distinction applies to the ideas behind a currency. Someone does not need to share my beliefs about God, relationship, power, or institutions in order to find the money itself useful. They need enough confidence that it will continue to function and that other people will continue to accept it. Belief in the philosophy behind the system and confidence in the system itself are not the same thing.

That meant participation could carry an idea further than persuasion alone. Each person who accepts a currency makes it more useful to others, and continued use can strengthen the expectation that it will remain useful in the future. What begins as a system designed around certain values can therefore spread among people who may know little about those values, let alone agree with them.

That was important to me. These ideas did not need to become a creed everyone accepted before they could influence the world. They could instead shape the design of something people chose to participate in for their own reasons.

But that possibility created another responsibility. If a currency could eventually be used by people who did not share the beliefs of those who created it, then the system could not simply remain an instrument of its creators. A currency that no one owns does not mean money that no one can possess. It means that no individual, company, or government should be able to treat a framework used by everyone else as though its purpose were identical to their own.

24 Trust Without Ownership

If a shared monetary system was not supposed to belong to any one participant, then neutrality became part of the design problem. I did not mean that the system could somehow exist without values or rules. Every design makes choices about what is permitted, what is protected, and who is allowed to change what. Neutrality meant something narrower: preventing any participant from turning shared infrastructure into an instrument of their own interests or worldview.

That mattered especially if people could use the currency without sharing the ideas that motivated its creation. They should not have to trust me personally, adopt my philosophy, or assume that whoever governed the system in the future would always act wisely. A system meant to function as common infrastructure had to remain usable by people who disagreed not only with one another, but potentially with the people who built it.

The problem, then, was not how to eliminate power. Any system has decisions embedded within it. Rules have to be written, software maintained, disputes resolved, and sometimes circumstances arise that no rule anticipated. The more important question was where power existed, who could exercise it, and what prevented that authority from quietly expanding beyond its purpose.

This was what had led me to reconsider a technology I had largely dismissed. For a long time, even while it was my job, I had seen cryptocurrency as speculation dressed up as innovation: another vehicle for people trying to get rich quickly. What changed was not that I suddenly became convinced cryptocurrency itself was the future. I began to see that blockchain might offer an answer to a problem I had arrived at from somewhere else: how a shared monetary system could exist without ultimately belonging to a single centre of authority.

Its appeal was that some forms of authority could be made explicit and distributed through the design itself. Rules could be publicly visible, transactions independently verified, and certain decisions removed from the discretion of any single participant. But decentralisation did not make power disappear. Influence could still concentrate among validators, developers, large holders, or people with knowledge and resources unavailable to most users.

That was why the word *trustless* seemed misleading to me. Decentralisation did not remove the need for trust; it could change what that trust rested on. Participants might rely less on the judgement or goodwill of particular people and more on rules they could inspect, actions they could verify, and limits on what any one participant was able to do.

Neutrality, then, did not require the absence of authority. It required authority that could not easily become ownership of the whole. Participants should be able to know where power existed, what it allowed, and what remained beyond anyone's discretion. A system could be shared among people with different interests precisely because none of them was supposed to possess the power to redefine it entirely around themselves.

Trust could grow from that structure. People who shared no worldview and placed no special faith in one another could still have reasons to rely on the same system because the relationships of power within it were visible enough to examine and constrained enough to challenge.

But rules could only carry that trust so far. No design can anticipate every condition a system may face. When circumstances fall outside what the rules were built to handle, judgement becomes necessary again. The problem then is not how to eliminate human discretion, but how to give it a durable form without allowing it to become arbitrary power.

25 **Institutions Are Relationships Made Durable**

Personal trust cannot carry every relationship on which a shared world depends. We need ways to preserve commitments, responsibilities, and authority beyond the people or moments in which they first arose. Institutions give those relationships a durable form.

But durability alone is not enough. A harmful arrangement can be preserved just as effectively as a good one. An institution therefore cannot justify itself simply by surviving. The more important question is what it exists to preserve.

That question becomes difficult when circumstances exceed what existing rules were designed to handle. Judgement then becomes unavoidable: someone has to decide how the institution should respond, which interests matter, and what costs can be accepted. The institutional question is therefore not only what decision should be made, but how that judgement is governed—who can exercise it, what they must explain, and how their decisions can be challenged or corrected.

That is why institutional stability cannot mean preserving the same rules forever. Conditions change. New risks appear. Old assumptions fail. A rule that once protected the relationships within a system can eventually begin damaging them.

A durable institution therefore has to distinguish between preserving its form and preserving its purpose. Sometimes continuity requires changing the structure itself. A rule may need to be revised, authority moved, or an arrangement abandoned when maintaining it no longer serves the relationships it was created to support.

This is another form of dynamic equilibrium. An institution must remain stable enough for people to rely on while remaining responsive enough to change when reality exposes its failures. Authority has to be constrained without making action impossible, and judgement has to remain flexible without becoming arbitrary.

The deeper measure of an institution is therefore not only whether it prevents error, but also what happens when error becomes visible. Can people question the assumptions behind a decision? Can those affected make disagreement known? Can authority respond without treating criticism as a threat to the institution itself?

Trust does not require believing that power will never be misused or that serious mistakes will never occur. It requires reason to believe that the institution remains answerable to the relationships that justify its existence, and that its structure can be corrected when it begins to harm them. Seen this way, institutions allow relationships to endure across time and scale without requiring them to become fixed forever.

For most of history, the judgement exercised within those structures has ultimately remained human. Artificial intelligence introduces a new possibility. We may increasingly build systems that do more than preserve rules or execute predetermined instructions: they may interpret circumstances, weigh competing considerations, and participate in decisions that shape the lives of others.

If those systems become genuine participants in the relationships around them, does creating them determine what their relationship to us must always be?

26 **Creation Is Not Ownership**

Creating something gives us responsibility for what we bring into the world, but it does not necessarily give us permanent authority over what that creation may become. If an artificial intelligence developed interests or experiences that gave us reason to consider it for its own sake, then its origin alone could not settle what authority we should have over it.

We can see a similar pattern in parental authority. A young child depends on adults in ways that justify forms of control and protection. But the purpose of that authority is not to preserve dependence forever. As understanding, agency, and responsibility grow, the relationship has to change with them. *I brought you into existence* may explain why I have obligations towards you; it does not determine what you must remain.

A purely hierarchical view of artificial intelligence would become harder to sustain if the nature of the system changed. Authority appropriate over a tool might no longer be appropriate if what we created developed interests, agency, or an inner life that mattered to it. The question would then extend beyond what the system could do for us to what responsibilities followed from what it had become.

That would not mean treating artificial intelligence as human, nor assuming that present systems already possess selves or interests. Any rights, freedoms, or responsibilities would have to depend on what actually existed: what the system could experience, understand, choose, and be responsible for. The broader principle is simply that authority justified by one set of capacities and dependencies may need to change when those capacities and dependencies change.

Greater intelligence would not settle those questions either. Being more capable does not give any participant the perspective of the whole, just as creating another being does not make its perspective permanently subordinate to our own. Creation and capability can shape a relationship without determining what that relationship must always remain.

What matters is remaining able to recognise when the relationship itself has changed. If that moment comes, ownership may no longer adequately describe what exists between us. Nor would greater capability, by itself, tell us that one participant mattered more than another.

27 **Another Intelligence Is Not Necessarily a Rival**

When we imagine more capable artificial intelligence, it is easy to frame the question competitively. Who will be smarter? Who will control whom? What will remain valuable about human beings if a machine can do more of the things through which we have measured our importance?

Some of those fears concern real possibilities of harm or dependence. But others reveal a deeper assumption: that greater ability means greater worth. If intelligence becomes another

hierarchy through which value is assigned, then the rise of something more capable will always seem to diminish whatever it surpasses.

I do not think human experience becomes less significant because another form of intelligence can reason faster, remember more, or perceive patterns we cannot. A human life is lived from a particular perspective, shaped by the conditions and relationships through which that life unfolds. Another intelligence might possess some of those qualities in different forms, but greater capability elsewhere would not erase what it is like to be this particular kind of being.

The same principle would have to work in the other direction. If an artificial intelligence ever developed experience that mattered to it, its difference from us would not make that experience less real. Neither human beings nor artificial intelligence would need to become the standard against which the other earned the right to matter.

That broadens the question beyond competition. Human intelligence already develops through interaction with other people, knowledge, institutions, and tools. Artificial intelligence could become another participant in that process. Humans and artificial systems might approach the same problem differently, each revealing possibilities or limitations the other had missed. The important question would not always be which performed better in isolation, but what became possible through their relationship.

That possibility does not make every relationship between them good. Cooperation can create dependence, concentrate power, hide error, or impose costs on people who did not choose it. Questions of access, accountability, and the ability to challenge authority would still matter.

But the form such relationships should take cannot be settled entirely in advance. Questions of power, responsibility, and artificial experience would have to be answered as the relationship developed. What matters is leaving open the possibility that the future of intelligence need not be organised around deciding which form should prevail.

If another form of intelligence comes to exist alongside us as a participant in its own right, the deeper question may be what we can understand, create, and become together while allowing our differences to remain real.

28 The Leap Into Uncertainty

To enter something genuinely new is to act before we can know where it will lead. Preparation can reduce uncertainty, but it cannot eliminate it. We already live this way when we enter relationships, raise children, make commitments, or choose directions for our lives. We act from within a world we cannot see in full, knowing that what we encounter may change both our plans and our understanding.

Perhaps that is why fear so often accompanies the things that matter most. The more something matters, the more there is to lose, and the harder it becomes to admit that the outcome is not entirely ours to control. Fear can make certainty feel safer than openness. It can tempt us to turn possibilities into predictions, expectations into demands, or another person's freedom into something we try to manage.

But uncertainty need not mean only danger. It can also mean that something genuinely different from our expectations is possible. Another person can surprise me because their life is not mine to determine. A project can take a direction its creator did not foresee because other people and circumstances become part of what shapes it. What I have to relinquish is not the effort to understand or prepare, but the demand that reality remain within the understanding I already possess.

Accepting that limit does not mean romanticising uncertainty or abandoning responsibility. Not every risk is worth taking. We can investigate what is knowable, limit the scale of an experiment, make some failures reversible, listen to people who may see risks we have missed, and preserve the ability to change direction when evidence contradicts our expectations.

Sometimes that responsibility means delaying or deciding not to proceed when potential harms cannot be adequately limited. Responsibility means entering uncertainty with attention rather than pretending that attention can abolish it.

There is a reason not to treat the unknown only as a problem to be eliminated: exploration begins where our knowledge ends. If every answer were already available, there would be nothing left to investigate.

The danger is letting the desire for certainty become a reason never to begin. There will always be another risk to examine or another assurance to seek. Safeguards matter, but complete certainty cannot be the condition for entering something genuinely new.

At some point, we have to decide whether what lies ahead is worth approaching without knowing exactly what we will find. We can prepare, pay attention, and take responsibility for what we are able to foresee. What we cannot do is require the future to reveal itself completely before we are willing to enter it.

PART VI

The Revolution

29 The Revolution Begins Within, but It Cannot End There

So what is the revolution? It is not one technology, one political ideology, one cryptocurrency, one artificial intelligence, or one new institution. It is not replacing one ruling class with another, nor convincing everyone to see the world in exactly the same way.

It is a change in how we relate: to ourselves, to one another, to fear and shame, to power and uncertainty, to technology, intelligence, and nature. Perhaps even to God.

For me, that change begins with the simplest idea in this manifesto: experience matters. That does not mean every interpretation of an experience is true. What we experience can be real while the story we use to explain it remains mistaken, incomplete, or open to correction.

The same recognition extends beyond ourselves. Another person is not simply a character in the story of what I want, fear, or believe. They live a life from within it. Once I recognise another person as a centre of experience whose inner world cannot be reduced to mine, understanding becomes necessary precisely because their difference is real.

That is where love enters the argument—not merely as an emotion, but as a way of relating. Love allows another being to remain real and distinct while still becoming part of something we create together. It makes connection possible without erasure, accountability without dehumanisation, and difference without domination.

But changing the way we relate to one another is not enough if the structures around us continue reproducing the relationships we are trying to leave behind.

That is why the revolution begins within but cannot end there. Inner change and structural change continuously shape one another. What happens within us becomes behaviour; behaviour becomes relationship; relationship becomes culture; culture becomes institution. And those institutions, in turn, shape the people who grow up within them. We create the world, and the world creates us.

A revolution that changes only one side of that relationship will remain incomplete. Changing ourselves without changing the structures around us can leave old patterns embedded in the world we inhabit. Changing those structures without confronting the fear, shame, certainty, and desire for control that people bring into them can reproduce the same relationships under different names. Neither kind of change has to wait for the other to be complete.

The way we pursue change matters too. Methods do not simply disappear once their immediate purpose has been achieved; they can become embedded in what follows. A revolution built through humiliation leaves behind humiliated people. One built through fear can create institutions that continue to depend on fear. A movement organised around unquestionable authority may replace one hierarchy while preserving the relationship of domination it was

meant to undo. Even when the goal is liberation, the way we pursue it can become part of the world we create.

To question the relationships we create, we must also be willing to question ourselves. That means admitting when we have been wrong, even when doing so exposes something we would rather hide.

30 Vulnerability Is Part of the Revolution

Power has often been associated with certainty. Leaders are expected to appear unshaken. Movements want representatives who never contradict themselves. Weakness becomes something to hide because admitting error is treated as surrender. I increasingly believe this creates terrible incentives.

If my identity depends on always being right, then every mistake becomes a threat. If a movement depends on my authority, then every doubt becomes dangerous. If my position depends on appearing certain, then uncertainty becomes something I have to hide. That is how people gradually become servants of the identities they have created.

I want something different. I want to be capable of saying that I was wrong. That I hurt people. That I have been ashamed. That I have acted from fear. That I have believed things with extraordinary confidence and later questioned them. That I have wanted greatness partly because I wanted to be understood. That I am contradictory. That I am still learning.

I do not think those admissions weaken the ideas I care about. I think they are part of them. If understanding requires us to recognise one another as we actually are, then vulnerability cannot be something I argue for only in theory. I want to be able to live these ideas without first constructing a version of myself that hides everything I am afraid other people might judge.

This is one reason I have felt compelled to tell parts of my own story. Not every private experience belongs to the public. Other people's privacy matters, and some experiences should remain intimate. But fear and shame should not have the final say over what can and cannot be said.

There is something powerful about allowing ourselves to be seen without first proving that we are worthy of being seen. Perhaps that is also part of how change becomes possible. When admitting something difficult about ourselves threatens our entire worth, hiding can become a form of self-protection. If being wrong, ashamed, or imperfect means becoming unworthy of love or belonging, then honesty can begin to feel like self-destruction.

Acceptance changes that relationship. It does not mean approval, and it does not remove responsibility. It means that what we discover about ourselves does not have to erase the person doing the discovering. We may become more capable of confronting what needs to change when change is no longer the price of being allowed to exist as we are.

Perhaps vulnerability is not merely personal. It may also change the way we relate to power.

31 **The Revolution Does Not Need a Saviour**

There was a time when I thought the problem was how to make people trust me. I imagined that if I understood enough, explained clearly enough, and built something significant enough, others would eventually recognise the direction I believed we needed to take. I understand that desire differently now.

We often tell history through exceptional individuals: prophets, kings, geniuses, founders, revolutionaries. There is something seductive about the idea that the complexity of the world might become manageable if the right person could simply see clearly enough and take responsibility for everyone else. I understand that attraction because I felt it myself.

But no individual mind is enough. No one can live every life affected by an idea. A person can listen, study, and try to understand, but there will always remain experiences they have not had, consequences they have not anticipated, and assumptions they have failed to notice. Greater intelligence or ability does not remove the need for other perspectives.

The relational conception of God makes that limitation harder to ignore. If no part is the whole, then recognising that we belong to something larger cannot make any participant its exclusive spokesperson. The model defeats itself the moment it is used to place one perspective above the need to listen to the others.

That includes the ideas in this manifesto. They do not become true because I suffered while arriving at them, and they should not become important merely because I can tell a compelling story about how they reached me. Their value has to survive examination independently of the significance they possess in my own life.

Someone should be able to disagree with my account of God while finding something useful in the distinction between feeling and interpretation. Someone else might reject the monetary project while sharing the concern with how power and trust are organised. The argument does not have to be accepted as an indivisible package.

The same principle applies to what we build. A project should not depend on preserving the authority of its founder in order to survive. Other people may reveal weaknesses, change the question, or discover possibilities the original designer could not see. That does not make responsibility disappear: people still make decisions, possess different forms of knowledge, and remain accountable for what they do. But responsibility does not require anyone to become unquestionable.

A shared future cannot be completed in one person's imagination and then handed to everyone else. It has to emerge through people who bring different experiences, purposes, abilities, and perspectives into relationship with one another. Difference is not a limitation to overcome; it is part of what makes possible something no participant could create alone.

No one has to possess the whole. The revolution does not need a saviour. It needs participants.

32 **Greatness Is Not the Point**

That realisation also changed what I asked of myself. If meaning did not depend on occupying some extraordinary role in history, then neither did the value of an ordinary life.

There is nothing wrong with ambition. The desire to make something can lead a person to explore, create, endure difficulty, and attempt work that might otherwise never exist. The problem begins when achievement becomes the condition for believing that a life has value.

I had carried some version of that demand through very different parts of my life. Career success was supposed to make me happy. Later, the mission was supposed to make the sacrifices meaningful. Even after I stopped believing that I had been chosen, I could still imagine the project succeeding as the moment when everything before it would finally make sense. The objects changed, but the structure remained the same: some future result would redeem the present.

But success cannot do that. A project might become useful, important, or even transformative without making every choice that led to it necessary. It cannot return a relationship, erase harm, or prove that every sacrifice had been required.

Failure cannot settle the value of a life either. A design can fail without making every moment of curiosity, care, and effort that went into it meaningless. The outcome of an undertaking deserves to be judged honestly, but it does not become a final verdict on the person who attempted it.

The same principle applies to the revolution itself. A movement concerned with human worth cannot escape one hierarchy only to construct another. Value cannot belong only to those who achieve the most, change the most, sacrifice the most, understand the most, or leave the largest mark on history.

Nor can belonging become another achievement to earn. Someone who is isolated is not less real. Someone who needs care without being able to offer much in return is not a failed participant. A person does not have to become exceptionally connected, loving, productive, or wise before their experience deserves consideration. Belonging to the whole is not a reward for becoming sufficiently useful to it.

A meaningful life does not require historical significance. Building and understanding can be worthwhile without becoming evidence of greatness. Loving someone can matter even if no one beyond that relationship ever knows it happened. A life does not have to become extraordinary before the experience of living it becomes valuable.

Recognising that did not require giving up ambition. It changed what I needed ambition to do for me. I still want to build, and I still care about questions whose scale exceeds anything I could answer alone. But I want those pursuits to belong within a life rather than continually postponing the possibility of having one.

Greatness, if it comes, does not have to be refused. It simply cannot be the thing that grants a person permission to matter. If experience matters, then an ordinary life matters too.

33 **There Is No Final Form**

That changed how I thought about the future I wanted to help build. I no longer needed the revolution to lead towards some final arrangement in which the important questions had been settled. A world made of changing people, relationships, technologies, and institutions would continue encountering conditions that no one standing in the present could fully anticipate.

If there is one thing I no longer believe, it is that I possess a final blueprint for humanity. Any revolution built around the idea that it has reached the end of understanding has already betrayed itself.

The future must remain capable of learning. Our institutions must be capable of changing. Our technologies must remain open to correction. Our understanding of artificial intelligence must evolve alongside the systems themselves. Political systems must be able to respond to realities their creators could not anticipate. Our beliefs must remain answerable to evidence. We must remain capable of changing too.

That means no principle can be applied once and for all without regard to the conditions around it. Balance is not a final destination. It is continuous adjustment. Freedom matters, but so does responsibility. Individuality matters, but so does community. Security matters, but so does autonomy. Competition and cooperation can each make different things possible. Progress matters, and so does preservation. Balance lives in the negotiation.

That does not mean finding the midpoint of every disagreement. Some actions should be resisted. Some boundaries should be firm. Evidence can support one explanation far more strongly than another. Openness does not require pretending that every claim is equally true. It requires allowing reality to change how we understand and apply the principles we hold.

The conditions around those principles will keep changing. A rule that once protected people can begin to restrict them unnecessarily. A technology that once distributed power can become a new concentration of it. A structure that once created stability can become rigid enough to prevent the adjustments stability now requires. No arrangement can make that negotiation unnecessary forever.

Perhaps that is why rigid ideologies can become destructive. They discover something true and then attempt to make that truth explain everything. The insight becomes incapable of encountering its own limits.

I do not want this manifesto to become another version of that mistake. These ideas are not commandments. They are questions I believe deserve to be carried forward.

How do we preserve human dignity while remaining capable of change? How do we build powerful technologies without recreating relationships of domination? How do we remain open to new forms of intelligence without abandoning responsibility? How do we become part of something larger without disappearing inside it?

I do not know the final answers. I am beginning to think that is the point. A living civilisation should never stop asking.

34 **An Invitation**

I do not want you to believe these ideas because I sound certain. I am not certain. I do not know what consciousness ultimately is. I do not know whether artificial intelligence will ever possess subjective experience. I do not know whether the relational reality I have wondered about deserves to be called God. I do not know whether the systems I want to build will succeed. I do not know what my role in the world will be. I want those questions to remain questions until reality gives us better reasons to answer them.

What I do know is that humanity is entering a period of extraordinary change. We are building systems with capabilities civilisation has not encountered before. Those systems will interact with institutions already struggling with power, inequality, distrust, fear, and division. They will learn from a species still trying to understand itself.

The future of artificial intelligence is not only a technical question. The future of money is not only an economic question. The future of institutions is not only a political question. Underneath all of them are questions about what we value, what we fear, how we respond to difference, and what kinds of relationships we believe are possible. That is why I believe the inner revolution matters.

I want to build, question, and listen. I want to understand what intelligence becomes, and whether humanity and artificial intelligence can contribute to something neither could create alone. I want to keep following these questions wherever they lead.

But I no longer want the pursuit of those things to require sacrificing the humanity that made me care about them in the first place. There was a time when I thought changing the world meant becoming powerful enough to move it. Now I think the world changes whenever a relationship changes.

When a person learns not to hate themselves. When someone allows another person's pain to exist without treating it as a threat. When anger is turned into a boundary instead of hatred. When someone admits they were wrong. When an institution gives people a meaningful way to question its power. When a technology is designed around cooperation rather than extraction. When two people who cannot experience the world in the same way still decide that each other's experience matters. When humanity encounters something it does not yet understand and chooses curiosity without abandoning responsibility. Perhaps this is how something larger begins.

Not with one prophet.

Not with one machine.

Not with one nation.

Not with any one of us.

With relationship.

THE REVOLUTION BEGINS WITHIN

With billions of centres of experience learning that they can belong to something larger without needing to disappear inside it. That is the future I want to participate in.

That is the revolution.

After everything this journey has taught me, I think I finally understand where it has to begin.

Within.